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Does the South have a possible history?

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Matters are bleak in the Global South. The locomotives of the South – the BRICS (Brazil, Russia, India, China, South Africa) – splutter as commodity prices drop. Some of this is attributable to the long-running credit crunch from 2007. Old Western fantasies to encage adversaries – whether China or Russia or indeed Iran – drive other problems. Sanctions against this country or that produce extra-economic blockades that are somehow immune to World Trade Organisation challenges – barriers to protect producers are illegal, but barriers to punish countries deemed to be outlaws are encouraged. The rouble spirals out of control, as US$30 billion goes to bail out Russia's Trust Bank.

What locomotives are able to leave the station do not have enough carriages to carry their populations. So inequality rates remain steady in Brazil, India and South Africa, all of which have seen 'orthodox' mechanisms take hold of their financial policy regardless of the temperament of their political leadership.

With certain exceptions, the slow decline of the trade unions and of membership in the mass fronts of the socialist and communist parties is a global problem – leaving many millions of people outside the influence of the Left. Jingoism of the Right pits the working class against itself – on the terrain of anti-immigrant politics, typically. Fellow workers become dry tinder, cowering in the corner as the lit match of jingoism flies around them. The explanations from the Left are more sober – more determined to show how the economic and political system in place pits workers against each other as capital sits back, smirking in its carefully crafted liberalism. But too many ordinary people are isolated from these sober explanations – now reliant as consumers for their theories on